required to stop the rot in Perth, which is rarely receptive to spin. He agreed, but in his head, he had already retired.

Perth was my 100th Test, and one of my most dispiriting. Swanny picked up three wickets but told me it had been the longest five days of his life. The last place he wanted to be was on a cricket field. His elbow hurt badly, but there was more to it than that. I looked into his eyes and knew that, mentally, he had gone. A light had been extinguished. He had hidden his hurt from his teammates, but the bubbly guy to whom everyone gravitated was consumed by sadness and frustration. I agreed to an announcement in Melbourne but, given my time again, would have asked him to keep our conversation confidential, and remain on tour for appearances' sake.

He wasn't stupid. He knew the uproar he would create. He accepted he would be portrayed as a bottler, a bloke who abandoned ship. No one has a divine right to play for England. Representing your country, reflecting your culture, is a special honour, to be treated with appropriate respect. His decision, in the middle of a series, was far from ideal, but I didn't feel fundamentally let down.

To go back to Flower's central point, Test cricket is quite literally a test of individual character. Who am I to say that Swanny hadn't made the harder, more courageous decision? He knew he had lost the necessary edge. The spark had gone. Instead of bottling it, had he simply realized he had nothing left? Maybe he just took the brave decision.

There wasn't time to process the answers, because problems were multiplying. Matt Prior, a stalwart of the team, was dropped for the final two Test matches. I had that so-called toilet chat. He was out of form and not doing himself justice. It suggested, to me, that he had been worn down by the intensity of international cricket.

It hurt, because he had turned up for the tour in the best physical shape I'd seen. He retained his hunger and ambition, but even those admirable qualities created tension because KP objected to him taking a leadership role in team meetings after his demotion. I felt his comments were a supportive gesture, and an indication of his devastation; Kevin appeared to be more suspicious.

Relationships were splintering. KP had a massive fallout with Graham Gooch on the balcony at Perth, after he had tried to hit Lyon out of the ground, into the wind, and was caught at deep long on by Harris. I sat